

Top 10 Fastballs in the 2027 Draft

When evaluating fastballs, velocity is only one piece of the equation. Modern fastball evaluation incorporates riding life, arm-side movement, release characteristics, command, approach angle, extension, and how effectively the pitch sets up the rest of an arsenal. The best fastball in college baseball is not always the hardest fastball. Among the 53 pitchers and 63 individual fastballs evaluated for this project, these were the ten fastballs that stood out most.

Number 10: Zachary Strickland, RHP, UCLA, Fastball (60)

Fastball Metrics: 93.5 | 19.5 IVB | 8.1 HB | -4.46 VAA | 5.9 RH | 6.0 EXT | 32.5 AA | 2340 RPM

Key Trait: The fastball cuts consistently when located glove side and plays flat into the zone

Strickland's fastball earns a place on this list because of how effectively it combines riding life with subtle cutting action. Nearly 20 inches of induced vertical break creates a pitch that remains above barrels, while the combination of extension and a shallow vertical approach angle allows it to play flatter than hitters expect. The result is a fastball that consistently misses barrels despite lacking the premium velocity seen among some of the pitches ranked ahead of it.

What makes the offering particularly intriguing is its ability to change shape based on location. When thrown glove side, the pitch develops a cutting action that allows Strickland to attack right-handed hitters on their hands while still maintaining enough ride to generate swings underneath the baseball. When located arm side, the pitch retains its above-average carry through the zone, creating a different look without sacrificing effectiveness. The versatility of the shape gives Strickland multiple ways to attack hitters with a single offering and forms the foundation of one of the more unique fastballs in the 2027 class.

Why #10: While it lacks the overwhelming velocity or singular movement profile of the pitches ranked ahead of it, Strickland's combination of ride, cut, and a flat approach into the zone creates a uniquely effective fastball that comfortably belongs among the ten best in the class.

Number 9: Rhys Bowie, LHP, Wake Forest, Fastball (60)

Fastball Metrics: 96.6 | 13.9 IVB | -10.8 HB | -3.86 VAA | 5.1 RH | 5.8 EXT | 21.7 AA | 2550 RPM

Key Trait: An unusually low release height allows the pitch to play with more carry than the raw movement numbers suggest

Bowie's fastball is one of the best examples in the class of why pitch evaluation extends beyond velocity and induced vertical break. At first glance, 13.9 inches of IVB does not resemble the profile of an elite riding fastball. In practice, however, the pitch behaves quite differently. Thrown from a low release height and a wide left-handed slot, the fastball enters the hitting zone on an exceptionally flat approach angle, creating the visual effect of a pitch that stays above barrels far longer than hitters anticipate.

The result is a fastball that consistently outperforms its raw movement characteristics. Hitters naturally associate Bowie's release with a pitch that should continue working downward through the zone. Instead, the pitch maintains a flat plane and carries through contact points where opponents often expect it to drop and explode above the barrel where hitters expect it to be deadzone. Pair the elite angle traits with 97 miles an hour of diesel and the resulting package is an offering that is extremely difficult to square up.

What separates Bowie from many hard-throwing left-handers is that the fastball does not need elite ride to be effective. The release characteristics and command up in the upper half of the zone do much of the heavy lifting. While several pitches ranked ahead of it possess more impressive raw movement profiles, few fastballs in the class create a larger disconnect between what hitters expect to see and what they actually receive.

Why #9: Bowie's fastball is a reminder that pitch effectiveness is not solely determined by movement metrics. The combination of velocity, release characteristics, and a uniquely flat approach into the zone allows the pitch to play like a premium riding fastball despite carrying significantly less induced vertical break than most pitchers in this range.

Number 8: Joshua Whritenour, RHP, Florida, Fastball (60)

Metrics: 97.7 | 18.0 IVB | 11.9 HB | -4.44 VAA | 6.09 RH | 5.68 EXT | 48.5 AA | 2490 RPM

Key Trait: Elite velocity paired with above-average ride creates a fastball capable of overpowering hitters in high-leverage situations.

Whritenour's fastball is one of the purest power pitches in the 2027 class. Sitting just under 98 mph with strong riding characteristics, the pitch places immediate pressure on hitters from the moment it leaves his hand. While many velocity-oriented fastballs sacrifice shape in exchange for pure speed, Whritenour maintains enough carry to consistently miss barrels and generate swing-and-miss against hitters who know the pitch is coming.

What separates the offering from other power fastballs is how little margin for error it gives the hitter. The combination of velocity, carry, and a relatively flat approach angle despite a release height north of six feet forces hitters to commit early, often leading to defensive swings or late contact. Even when contact is made, the pitch frequently overwhelms a hitter's ability to get the barrel into a favorable position.

The profile is especially effective in shorter stints where maximum intensity can be maintained throughout an outing. That trait was evident throughout Whritenour's freshman season at Florida, where the fastball consistently played at the upper end of its velocity band while serving as the foundation of a late-inning role. Few pitchers in the class can match the combination of velocity and ride that Whritenour brings to the mound, and the pitch consistently looks like a professional weapon when featured aggressively.

Why #8: Whritenour possesses one of the hardest fastballs in the class, and unlike many upper-90s offerings in the college ranks, the pitch comes with enough shape to remain effective beyond pure velocity alone. The pitches ranked ahead of it offer either more unique movement profiles or stronger overall characteristics, but few fastballs can rival the raw power of Whritenour's heater.

Number 7: Will Sanford, RHP, Oregon, Fastball (60)

Metrics: 93.4 | 21.5 IVB | 9.4 HB | -3.89 VAA | 5.7 RH | 6.5 EXT | 37.4 AA | 2470 RPM

Key Trait: Elite carry and ride paired with advanced execution allow the pitch to function as both a bat-missing weapon above the zone and a strike-stealing offering at the bottom.

Sanford's fastball is one of the premier riding fastballs in the 2027 class. Sitting 93-95 mph with an elite -3.89 VAA and 21.5 inches of induced vertical break, the pitch consistently plays above its velocity and allows Sanford to attack hitters in ways few pitchers can. The combination generated a 30% whiff rate, a 14% swinging-strike rate, and 134 total whiffs during the 2026 season.

The pitch is at its best when elevated. The combination of ride, extension, and approach angle creates a fastball that remains above barrels longer than hitters expect, producing frequent empty swings and weak contact. When located just above the strike zone, the offering generated a 47% chase rate and a 43% whiff rate, illustrating just how difficult it is for hitters to resist. What separates Sanford from many other riding-fastball pitchers is his ability to weaponize the pitch in multiple parts of the strike zone. While the elevated version earns most of the attention, Sanford consistently demonstrated the ability to land the pitch at the bottom of the zone and steal strikes with it. The natural carry keeps the ball on plane long enough to freeze hitters, creating a second look without requiring a different pitch.

Few pitchers in the class combine ride, carry, extension, and command as effectively as Sanford. The result is a fastball capable of generating swings and misses, stealing strikes, and controlling at-bats from the first pitch to the last.

Why #7: Sanford possesses one of the most complete fastball profiles in the class. The pitches ranked ahead of it offer either more velocity or more extreme movement characteristics, but few fastballs are as versatile or as consistently effective throughout the strike zone.

Number 6: Rhys Bowie, LHP, Wake Forest, Sinker (60)

Metrics: 96.0 | 8.2 IVB | -18.0 HB | -5.40 VAA | 5.1 RH | 5.8 EXT | 16.0 AA | 2330 RPM

Key Trait: Elite arm-side movement and the ability to consistently locate the pitch down and arm side create one of the most difficult sinkers in the class to square up.

Making his second appearance on this list, Bowie's sinker serves as a perfect complement to his four-seam fastball and gives him a completely different way to attack hitters. At 96 mph with 18 inches of arm-side movement, the pitch is built to generate poor contact, particularly against left-handed hitters. Bowie consistently showed the ability to drive the ball to the bottom of the strike zone and work it toward the hands of same-sided hitters, producing a remarkable .067 batting average, 35.7% whiff rate, and 81.8% ground-ball rate against left-handed opposition.

What separates the pitch from many other power sinkers is its movement profile. The combination of velocity, arm-side movement, and a steep approach into the zone creates a pitch that is constantly moving away from barrels. Even when hitters appear to have the pitch timed, the lateral movement frequently shifts the contact point enough to prevent flush contact. The sinker also plays well against right-handed hitters. The substantial arm-side movement allows Bowie to attack the inner half of the plate, creating opportunities to front-hip the pitch or force weak contact off the handle. Few hitters are comfortable seeing a pitch with this much movement arrive at this type of velocity.

Why #6: Bowie's sinker combines premium velocity with elite arm-side movement and exceptional results. The pitches ranked above it offer either more complete fastball traits or greater overall impact, but few sinkers in college baseball are capable of generating this combination of whiffs and ground balls.

Number 5: Sam Cozart, RHP, Texas, Fastball (60)

Metrics: 94.0 | 19.7 IVB | 6.4 HB | -4.58 VAA | 6.2 RH | 6.6 EXT | 42.7 AA | 2230 RPM

Key Trait: Exceptional conviction throwing the pitch throughout the strike zone allows elite ride to play in multiple ways.

Cozart's fastball was simply dominant in 2026. Opposing hitters went just 8-for-68 against the pitch while producing a 38.7% whiff rate and 19.1% swinging-strike rate. The combination of nearly 20 inches of induced vertical break and 6.6 feet of extension allowed the pitch to bully hitters despite operating at a velocity band that is merely above average by elite college standards.

The defining characteristic of the pitch is how aggressively Cozart uses it. While many carry-oriented fastballs are deployed almost exclusively at the top of the strike zone, Cozart demonstrated a willingness to attack hitters both at the top and bottom of the zone. Elevated fastballs generated the bulk of the swing-and-miss, while lower fastballs frequently froze hitters for called strikes. The ability to create two distinct looks with the same pitch gives the heater more versatility than many of the fastballs on this list.

The best example of the pitch came during Texas' Austin Super Regional matchup against Oregon. Tasked with protecting a late lead against a loaded Ducks lineup, Cozart recorded five of six outs via the fastball, including three swinging strikeouts. The outing concluded with a 96 mph fastball carrying nearly 19 inches of induced vertical break past Oregon veteran Ryan Cooney. For a freshman pitcher, it was one of the most impressive high-leverage sequences of the entire season.

What makes the pitch especially effective is its simplicity. There is very little arm-side movement present, with the shape occasionally leaning toward subtle cut characteristics. The pitch succeeds because hitters consistently struggle to match their swing plane with its elite carry and extension combination. Even when they know it is coming, they often cannot square it up.

Why #5: Few fastballs in the class paired elite results with elite movement characteristics as effectively as Cozart's. The pitches ranked above it offer either greater velocity or more unique movement profiles, but Cozart's heater was one of the most dominant and reliable weapons in college baseball during 2026.

Number 4: Sean Jenkins, RHP, ECU, Sinker (60)

Metrics: 95.5 | 11.8 IVB | 17.5 HB | -6.21 VAA | 54.1 AA | 2160 RPM

Key Trait: Hard, late arm-side movement paired with upper-90s velocity allows the pitch to overwhelm both left-handed and right-handed hitters.

Jenkins' sinker is the first fastball on this list that truly blurs the line between contact-management weapon and put-away pitch. As the primary fastball in his arsenal, the pitch combines elite velocity, substantial arm-side movement, and enough depth to consistently pressure the bottom of the strike zone. Getting over 17 inches of arm-side run while maintaining mid-to-upper 90s velocity is rare in its own right. Pairing that movement profile with a steep approach into the zone makes the offering one of the most difficult fastballs in the class to square up.

What separates the pitch from many power sinkers is its versatility. Jenkins demonstrated the ability to throw it to both sides of the plate, allowing the movement to play differently depending on location. When located arm side, the pitch runs away from barrels and forces defensive swings. When thrown glove side, the movement continues to work back toward the strike zone, giving hitters an entirely different look while maintaining the same velocity and movement characteristics. The underlying results support the eye test. The sinker generated a 54% ground-ball rate, did not allow a home run during the 2026 season, and surrendered an average exit velocity of just 86.6 mph. Those numbers highlight a pitch capable of generating weak contact even when hitters manage to put it in play. At the same time, it remained a legitimate bat-missing weapon, recording the strikeout on 35% of two-strike sinkers thrown. Few fastballs in the class possess the combination of strike-getting ability, contact management, and put-away potential that Jenkins brings with his sinker. The movement profile is extreme, the velocity is elite, and the results consistently matched the raw traits.

Why #4: Jenkins' sinker combines velocity, movement, and effectiveness in a way few fastballs can. The pitches ranked above it possess either more complete overall profiles or even greater carrying value, but Jenkins owns one of the most dominant sinkers in college baseball and one of the most unique fastballs in the 2027 class.

Number 3: Tomas Valincius, LHP, Miss. State, Sinker (60)

Metrics: 94.7 | 11.0 IVB | -16.7 HB | -6.07 VAA | 5.8 RH | 5.9 EXT | 29.1 AA | 2290 RPM

Key Trait: Left-handed velocity with plus ASR creates one of the premier sinkers in college baseball.

The sinker is the engine of Valincius' repertoire and the foundation of one of the best starter profiles in the class. Averaging nearly 95 mph with over 16 inches of arm-side movement, the pitch combines velocity, movement, and command in a way few collegiate left-handers can match. The velocity allows the pitch to challenge hitters within the strike zone, while the movement consistently shifts barrels away from the baseball and produces weak contact.

What makes the offering especially effective is its ability to attack both sides of the plate. Valincius shows confidence running the pitch beneath left-handed barrels while consistently jamming and front-hipping right-handed hitters, forcing defensive swings even when they correctly identify the pitch. The movement remains late enough that hitters frequently struggle to square it up despite knowing it is coming. His ability to command the pitch to both edges creates a true "two-pitch" effect, allowing the sinker to play as two distinct weapons depending on location.

Unlike many sinkers that function primarily as contact-management offerings, Valincius' version has enough velocity to overpower hitters outright. The combination of mid-90s velocity and elite arm-side movement creates a fastball capable of generating both ground balls and swing-and-miss, a rare quality among collegiate sinkers. When paired with the rest of his arsenal, it allows him to control at-bats from the first pitch and consistently work from advantageous counts. The pitch also serves as the perfect foundation for a starter's workload. Rather than relying solely on chase or deception, Valincius can repeatedly attack the zone, generate weak contact, and preserve pitch efficiency while still missing bats when necessary. Few fastballs in the class blend durability, effectiveness, and raw stuff as well as this one.

Why #3: Valincius possesses one of the most complete sinkers in the country. The pitches ranked above it feature even greater raw fastball traits, but few offerings combine velocity, movement, command, and workload utility as effectively as this pitch. For a professional organization searching for a foundational starter's fastball, this is as good as it gets.

Number 2: Jackson Barberi, RHP, Florida, Fastball (60)

Metrics: 97.3 | 21.0 IVB | 11.1 HB | -4.44 VAA | 6.33 RH | 5.4 EXT | 46.0 AA | 2540 RPM

Key Trait: Dominant velocity and elite ride paired with exceptional spin create one of the most explosive fastballs in the class.

Barberi's fastball is the definition of a power pitch. Sitting 97-99 mph and reaching triple digits, the offering combines elite velocity with 21 inches of induced vertical break and 98th-percentile spin rates. The result is a fastball that appears to gain life as it approaches the plate, consistently beating hitters above barrels despite operating in velocity bands where many fastballs begin to flatten out.

The pitch's effectiveness stems from more than pure velocity. Barberi attacks aggressively throughout the upper half of the strike zone, using the combination of ride and late life to generate empty swings and poor contact. While the overall zone rate remains lower than some of the pitchers ranked behind him, the command is often better than the raw number suggests. He has shown an ability to work glove side and elevate with conviction, allowing the slight arm-side movement to pull pitches back toward the strike zone against right-handed hitters and nearly front-hip left-handed hitters.

The results against elevated contact were exceptional in 2026. Opponents hit just .143 against fastballs located in the upper half of the strike zone while producing a 35.6% whiff rate. Few pitchers in the class can generate that combination of velocity and bat-missing ability with a single pitch. The shape is powerful enough to miss bats on its own, yet refined enough to set up the rest of the arsenal.

There is still room for refinement. Arm-side command can occasionally falter, causing pitches to leak inside rather than compete in the zone. Further, Barberi generates only average extension numbers. Despite this, the combination of velocity, spin, and ride allows the pitch to maintain an exceptionally effective approach into the zone and keeps hitters consistently uncomfortable.

Why #2: Barberi possesses one of the loudest pure fastball profiles in amateur baseball. The combination of upper-90s velocity, elite ride, and exceptional spin creates a pitch capable of overpowering hitters at every level. Only one fastball in the class combines raw stuff, shape, and overall effectiveness more completely.

Number 1: Dax Whitney, RHP, Oregon State, Fastball (65)

Metrics: 97.1 | 18.7 IVB | 2.2 HB | -4.69 VAA | 6.38 RH | 6.54 EXT | 55.1 AA | 2400 RPM

Key Trait: Cut-ride velocity paired with exceptional extension creates arguably the most complete fastball in the 2027 class.

Whitney's fastball is the standard by which every other fastball in this class is measured.

Averaging 97.1 mph while touching triple digits, the pitch combines elite velocity, nearly 19 inches of induced vertical break, outstanding extension, and a remarkably efficient approach angle into a single package. Very few amateur fastballs possess this combination of raw power and underlying characteristics.

What elevates the pitch beyond pure velocity is how difficult it is for hitters to make quality swing decisions against it. The slight cut shape keeps the pitch from drifting excessively arm side while the carry allows it to maintain plane through the top of the zone. Combined with 6.54 feet of extension, the fastball effectively shortens reaction time and forces hitters to commit earlier than they would prefer. The result is a pitch that consistently beats barrels even when hitters correctly identify it out of hand. The production matched the traits in 2026. Despite throwing the pitch more than half the time, Whitney generated a 36.3% whiff rate and 35.6% CSW rate, numbers that would be impressive for a breaking ball, let alone a primary fastball. He showed confidence attacking hitters in all counts, frequently challenging opponents with the pitch even when they knew it was coming. Very few collegiate fastballs can function as both a foundational strike getter and a premier put-away weapon. Whitney's does exactly that.

The pitch also serves as the catalyst for the rest of the arsenal. Hitters must commit so much attention to handling the velocity and carry that his secondary offerings consistently benefit. That dynamic is a hallmark of elite fastballs at every level of baseball, and Whitney's heater embodies it as well as any pitch in the class.

Why #1: No fastball in the 2027 class combines velocity, ride, extension, command, and results as completely as Whitney's. Other pitches on this list may rival it in their parts, but none can match the total package. It is a true plus-plus offering and the best fastball in the 2027 college pitching class.